Microsoft | Microsoft for Startups

Microsoft for Startups

Build fast, scale smart, sell more

The startup landscape today

AI is accelerating a foundational change in how we build, work, and create.

Agentic AI is becoming the new competitive edge.

Startups are not just expected to grow, but to grow fast and reliably.

Partners, platform, and performance are more important than ever.

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The rise of agentic AI: a new era for startups

- AI is no longer a feature; it's the foundation. Startups are building with agents from day one.
- The future of software is agentic: modular, orchestrated, and deeply integrated with enterprise data.
- Microsoft is leading this shift with a full-stack approach: infrastructure, orchestration, and interaction layers.

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Leading the way in AI

Azure OpenAI

- Azure OpenAI empowers developers to build cutting-edge AI applications through direct access to OpenAI models (i.e. GPT models) backed by Azure's enterprise-grade capabilities.

AI Foundry

- With Azure AI Foundry you can select models, fine-tune, and evaluate in a unified CLI-driven workflow. Built-in A/B testing, model routing, and support help you deploy with precision.

Responsible AI

- Every AI product we develop is guided by our six responsible AI principles: fairness, reliability and safety, privacy and security, inclusiveness, transparency, and accountability.

Copilot

- Using advanced AI, Copilot answers questions and assists with writing and image creation.
- GitHub Copilot helps you write code faster and with less effort, allowing you to focus on problem solving and collaboration.

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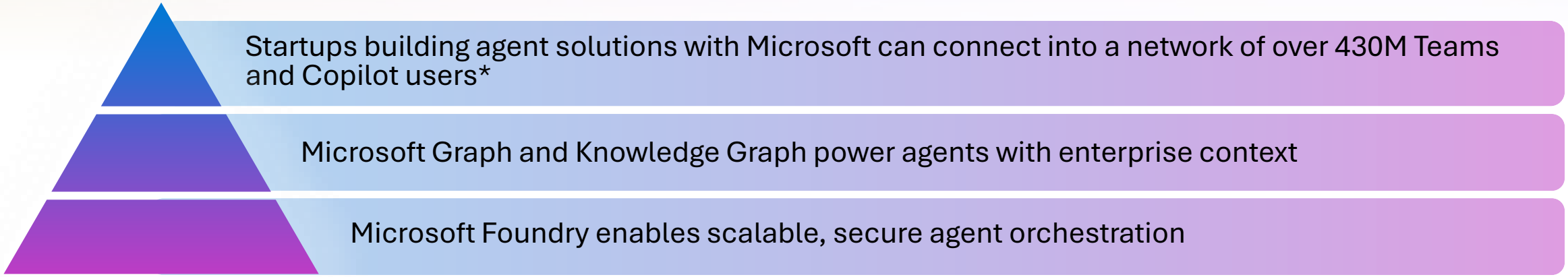
Microsoft empowers all users to build agents with tools across the developer spectrum

The agent stack



Tools

Copilot Studio

Visual Studio

GitHub

*Source: Microsoft Fiscal Year 2025 Third Quarter Earnings

AI for Education

Training | Products | Career Paths | Browse all training | Learn for Organizations | Educator Center | Student Hub | FAQ & Help

MICROSOFT LEARN EDUCATOR CENTER

AI for education: Resources and learning opportunities

Explore resources and training on how to use artificial intelligence (AI) for educational purposes with Microsoft.

Browse all Educator Center training

Educator Center trainings

Create instructional materials with Teach in Microsoft 365 Copilot

Use AI-powered tools to plan instruction, assess learning, and manage class artifacts in Microsoft 365.

Introduce AI and data science in STEM education with FarmBeats for Students

Engage learners with AI and data science through the FarmBeats for Students program.

Embark on your AI journey with free AI tools from Microsoft Education

Educators are introduced to the powerful AI tools Microsoft offers for free to educators and learners.

Empower educators to explore the potential of artificial intelligence

Navigate AI in education by looking at essential AI concepts, techniques, and tools.

AI for education | Microsoft Learn

In a world where AI is reshaping every industry, how do startups get the tools, the trust, and the traction to lead?

This is where Microsoft for Startups steps in.

How startups work with Microsoft for Startups

Build fast: free Azure credits to get started quickly

Access to Azure AI Foundry to build, deploy, and manage AI apps and agents across >10k models, including Grok3 and Flux Pro 1.1

Scale smart: leverage best in class AI tools

Technical support, industry expertise, and access to tools like GitHub Enterprise, LinkedIn Premium, and M365

Sell more: boost Go-To-Market success

Get access to Microsoft's global network of enterprise customers

Build fast on Azure- with security, privacy, and supercomputing power built in

Azure credits to help you get started

- Build with free with access to up to $150k in Azure credits for two years. You may be eligible for more credits over time as you grow and scale.

End-to-end AI development

- Azure credits can be used on all models hosted directly via AI Foundry including Azure OpenAI, Grok 3, Llama 4 Scout & Maverick, and more.

Advanced AI security and privacy standards

- Azure maintains the largest compliance portfolio in the industry.
- On Azure, you own your data—we will never use it for marketing or advertising purposes.

Supercomputing Power for AI

- Azure hosts the most advanced supercomputer in the world and is the exclusive cloud provider for OpenAI.
- Startups can get access to on-demand GPU VMs for tasks like fine-tuning models or training your own.

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Scale smart with AI tools and expert guidance

Microsoft for Startups supports startups every step of the way, from getting started fast to building on your success with the help of our experts.

- **Start here:** Deploy in minutes with our pre-built AI templates.
- **Build here:** Get free or discounted access to GitHub Enterprise, LinkedIn Premium, M365 Business Premium, Microsoft Clarity, Visual Studio Enterprise, and more.
- **Grow here:** Lean on technical and business support from industry experts to accelerate your growth.

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Sell more with go-to-market support

Navigate selling into enterprise

- Microsoft brings decades of enterprise sales expertise to startups—helping them refine their value proposition, align technical architecture, and navigate the complexity of selling into large organizations with confidence.

Generate awareness through joint marketing

- Gain credibility and visibility by aligning with one of the most trusted names in tech. We showcase startup stories across Microsoft-branded channels to build trust, attract customers, and accelerate growth.

Reach millions of potential customers

- Tap into Microsoft's global customer network. We fast-track startups into selling with Microsoft, with the most engaged Azure builders receiving prioritized customer connections and GTM support.

Accelerate enterprise sales

- We help accelerate a startup's path to the Commercial Marketplace, enabling them to bypass enterprise procurement hurdles and allowing customers to draw down on their Azure commitments when purchasing startup solutions.

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Vibe coding with Microsoft - resources

Developer Vibe coding

- Vibe coding is an AI-assisted way of building software where developers describe what they want in natural language and let Copilot generate and iterate on the code.
- In Azure, this is enabled mainly through **GitHub Copilot (Agent Mode) in VS Code / Visual Studio,** integrated with Azure services and cloud architectures.

Power Apps vibe

The vibe experience transforms how you build business applications by combining three key capabilities in a single, integrated workspace:

- Rapid prototyping
- Unified development
- AI-powered assistance

Overview of the new Power Apps vibe experience - Power Apps | Microsoft Learn

Learn & Guides

- Introduction to Vibe Coding - Training | Microsoft Learn
- Complete Beginner's Guide to Vibe Coding an App in 5 Minutes - Microsoft for Developers
- Vibe coding makes prototyping close to code, closer to users - Microsoft Design.

Eligibility criteria for startups working with an Investor-Network affiliated investor

To be eligible for the Microsoft for Startups investor offer as startup must meet the following criteria:

- **Startup** must be affiliated with an investor who is a part of the Microsoft for Startups Investor Network.

  Please note that we cannot publicly share the list of participating investors. To obtain a referral code, you'll need to contact your investor (accelerator or VC) directly.
- **Startup** is engaged in the development of a software-based product or service that is a core part of their current or intended business. The software must be owned and not licensed from another party.
- **Startup** has received fewer than $350,000 in lifetime free Azure credits.
- **Startup** is headquartered in a country where Azure services are available.
- **Startup** has not raised Series C funding.
- **Startup** is privately held.
- **Startup** is a for-profit business.
- **Startup** isn't an educational institution, government organization, personal blog, development shop, consultancy, agency, or involved in bitcoin or crypto mining.

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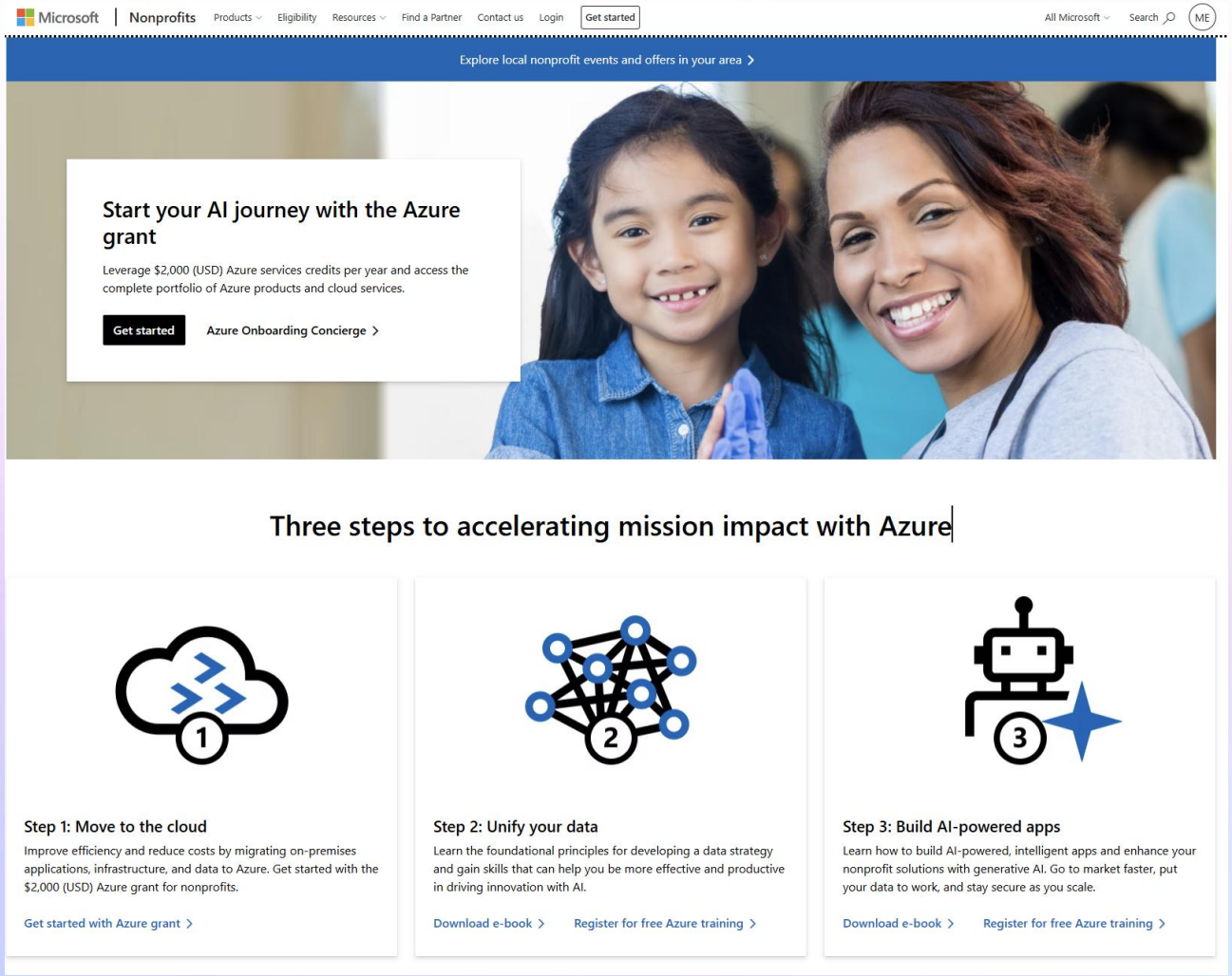
Microsoft for Nonprofits



Azure cloud solutions | Microsoft for Nonprofits

How to get started with Microsoft for Startups for your KwaXolo project

Included in the program

- Affiliated startups will start at $10,000 USD and based on usage can access up to $25,000 USD
- Credits can be used on all eligible models hosted directly via AI Foundry including Azure OpenAI, Grok 3, Llama 4 Scout & Maverick and hundreds of additional models
- 24/7 Azure Standard Support
- Dedicated technical support, office hours, and learning sessions
- Unlimited pairing sessions with Azure engineers for more strategic conversations
- Free access to GitHub Enterprise
- Free access to Visual Studio Enterprise

Guidelines for responsible code-sharing

Treat codes as strategic and confidential	You should avoid sharing your unique referral code publicly. Sharing should be intentional, private, and within your vetted network.
Share only with eligible startups	To protect the experience for all parties, referral codes should only be shared for startups in your current portfolio or graduated alumni.
Trust-based recommendation	Emphasize access to the Microsoft for Startups program is selective and your code reflects a strong, trust-based recommendation.
Monitor for responsible use	Let us know if you notice any unintended use of your code or suspect it has been shared too broadly. We will help you reissue a code.
Lead with values	We invite you to treat the code-sharing process as a reflection of our shared partnership and responsibility to help great startups grow with Microsoft.

To access these benefits:

1. Visit https://startups.microsoft.com
2. Follow prompts on the website to redeem your referral code
3. Enter our unique partner code when prompted: **928JGBDMCL**

Useful links

- Microsoft for Startup website: Microsoft for Startups | Microsoft
- How to apply & eligibility: Overview of the Microsoft for Startups application process | Microsoft Learn
- Application (choose “apply with your code”):Microsoft for Startups
- Benefit overview (Azure and Microsoft tools): Microsoft for Startups Investor Offer Benefits | Microsoft Learn
- Azure Credit Offer: Azure Credit Offer | Microsoft Learn
- How to book in Azure technical specialist: Technical Guidance & Support Overview | Microsoft Learn
- Activation of Azure Credits: Azure Activation FAQs | Microsoft Learn
- AI for startups: Microsoft AI - Startups Hub | Microsoft Learn
- GtM support & Co Sell: A faster go-to-market path for startups: Intellectual Property co-sell at Microsoft for Startups - Microsoft for Startups Blog
- Marketplace resources: Mastering the SaaS Accelerator - Mastering the Marketplace

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